

# Cliff Notes: a time for caution

[#cliffnotes](#)[#rba](#)[#australia](#)[#inflation](#)[#us](#)[#fomc](#)[#ecb](#)[#aud](#)[#usd](#)

By [Elliot Clarke](#) & [Ryan Wells](#)

08:58 March 13 2026

 Share

Key insights from the week that was.



The [Westpac-MI Consumer Sentiment Index](#) lifted modestly in March, up 1.2% to 91.6, still an outright pessimistic reading. The latest survey was in the field over the week to March 7, so it only captured part of this week's conflict escalation in the Middle East. Responses over the last three days of the sample were closer to an index read of 84 – a deeply pessimistic result which emphasises just how dynamic sentiment is to the situation offshore.

Underscoring the slightly firmer headline result in the month was an improvement in current assessments of family finances (+1.8%), buyer sentiment (4.9%) and the economy in five years' time (2.4%). This more than offset the flat and weaker readings on the year-ahead view for family finances and the economy respectively. Many of the near-term nerves stem from consumers' hawkish mortgage rate expectations, with over 75% of respondents anticipating a lift over the next twelve months.

Recent commentary from RBA officials has continued to emphasise the Board's pessimistic view on supply capacity, concerns over the persistence of domestic inflation and their desire to keep price expectations anchored. Now facing an additional threat from offshore in the form of surging energy prices, the RBA is likely to feel compelled to act without delay. Responding to these developments, Chief Economist Luci Ellis this week announced a revision to our RBA profile, adding an additional 25bp rate hike next week at the March meeting, in addition to the hike already forecast for May. This cumulative 50bps of tightening will take the cash rate back to its post-pandemic peak of 4.35%. The breadth, intensity and persistence of inflation risks stemming from the conflict are highly uncertain and skewed upward near term, but should fade through 2027, allowing a reversal of 2026's rate hikes from late-2027.

Before moving offshore, it is worth noting that the latest NAB business survey suggests optimism among Australian businesses largely evaporated in February. Not only does this coincide with weaker reads on consumer sentiment, but also a somewhat softer start to the year for trading conditions and profitability. This foreshadows a plateauing of economic growth after an acceleration to near trend over the course of 2025.

In the US, current assessments and expectations of the labour market were re-written last Friday. US nonfarm payrolls surprised to the downside in February, declining 92k in the month. Gains over the prior two months were also revised down 69k, leaving the 3-month average at just 6k versus 50k in January, and the 12-month average around 13k compared to 89k the year prior. The unemployment rate also ticked up to 4.4% despite a 0.1ppt decline in the participation rate. More significantly, annual revisions reduced the participation rate and employment-to-population ratio by 0.4ppts and 0.5ppts respectively. These outcomes point to US labour supply being constrained by both structural and cyclical factors, risking economic growth into the medium term.

That said, to date economic growth has held up, as highlighted by January retail sales – the control group up 0.3%. Housing starts also showed some life in January, up 7.2%, although the level of starts is still 18% below its 2022 peak and permits are weaker still, 28% below. The run up in US term interest rates into the end of the week meanwhile signals growing risks for US inflation and financial conditions. This is particularly troubling for the US, coming at a time when labour market data warrants further easing. Our full updated expectations for the US economy and interest rates can be found in March Market Outlook, out today on Westpac IQ.

Finally to China. The January/February trade data highlighted the continued success of China's rapid expansion of high-tech manufacturing and related infrastructure, exports up 21.8% year-to-date and the trade surplus near its widest mark at \$213.6bn (for the two months combined). Persistent strength in the trade surplus is a core expectation of our China forecasts. But, after near 20% gains for several

years, growth in external demand must slow. As discussed in the last edition of Cliff Notes and March Market Outlook, pro-active stimulus is necessary to accelerate domestic demand from H1 2026. The greater the risk for global energy prices and supply, the more pressing the need for action.

## Stay informed with Westpac IQ

Get the latest reports straight to your inbox.

Subscribe

### Related articles



#cliffnotes

### Cliff Notes: a fork in the road

March 27 2026 • ⌚ 5 mins

By [Elliot Clarke](#) & [Ryan Wells](#)





#cliffnotes

## Cliff Notes: fear overwhelms

March 20 2026 • ⌚ 5 mins

By [Elliot Clarke](#), [Ryan Wells](#) & [Mantas Vanagas](#)



#cliffnotes

# Cliff Notes: known and unknown risks

March 06 2026 • ⌚ 5 mins

By [Elliot Clarke](#), [Illiana Jain](#) & [Ryan Wells](#)

## Browse topics

#aud

#interestrates

#australia

#nzd

#usd

#rates

#credit

#yieldcurve

#newzealand

#acgb

#semigovernment

#basis

#commodities

#ustreasury

#fx

#rba

#jpy

#abs

#rbnz

#inflation

Show more tags

## **Disclaimer**

©2026 Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 (including where acting under any of its Westpac, St George, Bank of Melbourne or BankSA brands, collectively, “Westpac”). References to the “Westpac Group” are to Westpac and its subsidiaries and includes the directors, employees and representatives of Westpac and its subsidiaries.

## **Things you should know**

We respect your privacy: You can view the [New Zealand Privacy Policy](#) here, or the [Australian Group Privacy Statement](#) here. Each time someone visits our site, data is captured so that we can accurately evaluate the quality of our content and make improvements for you. We may at times use technology to capture data about you to help us to better understand you and your needs, including potentially for the purposes of assessing your individual reading habits and interests to allow us to provide suggestions regarding other reading material which may be suitable for you.

This information, unless specifically indicated otherwise, is under copyright of the Westpac Group. None of the material, nor its contents, nor any copy of it, may be altered in any way, transmitted to, copied or distributed to any other party without the prior written permission of the Westpac Group.

## **Disclaimer**

This information has been prepared by Westpac and is intended for information purposes only. It is not intended to reflect any recommendation or financial advice and investment decisions should not be based on it. This information does not constitute an offer, a solicitation of an offer, or an inducement to subscribe for, purchase or sell any financial instrument or to enter into a legally binding contract. To the extent that this information contains any general advice, it has been prepared without taking into account your objectives, financial situation or needs and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the advice. Certain types of transactions, including those involving futures, options and high yield securities give rise to substantial risk and are not suitable for all investors. We recommend that you seek your own independent legal or financial advice before proceeding with any investment decision.

This information may contain material provided by third parties. While such material is published with the necessary permission none of Westpac or its related entities accepts any responsibility for the accuracy or completeness of any such material. Although we have made every effort to ensure this information is free from error, none of Westpac or its related entities warrants the accuracy, adequacy or completeness of this information, or otherwise endorses it in any way. Except where contrary to law, Westpac Group intend by this notice to exclude liability for this information. This information is subject to change without notice and none of Westpac or its related entities is under any obligation to update this information or correct any inaccuracy which may become apparent at a later date. This information may contain or incorporate by reference forward-looking statements. The words “believe”, “anticipate”, “expect”, “intend”, “plan”, “predict”, “continue”, “assume”, “positioned”, “may”, “will”, “should”, “shall”, “risk” and other similar expressions that are predictions of or indicate future events and future trends identify forward-looking statements. These forward-

looking statements include all matters that are not historical facts. Past performance is not a reliable indicator of future performance, nor are forecasts of future performance. Whilst every effort has been taken to ensure that the assumptions on which any forecasts are based are reasonable, the forecasts may be affected by incorrect assumptions or by known or unknown risks and uncertainties. The ultimate outcomes may differ substantially from any forecasts.

**Conflicts of Interest:** In the normal course of offering banking products and services to its clients, the Westpac Group may act in several capacities (including issuer, market maker, underwriter, distributor, swap counterparty and calculation agent) simultaneously with respect to a financial instrument, giving rise to potential conflicts of interest which may impact the performance of a financial instrument. The Westpac Group may at any time transact or hold a position (including hedging and trading positions) for its own account or the account of a client in any financial instrument which may impact the performance of that financial instrument.

**Author(s) disclaimer and declaration:** The author(s) confirms that (a) no part of his/her compensation was, is, or will be, directly or indirectly, related to any views or (if applicable) recommendations expressed in this material; (b) this material accurately reflects his/her personal views about the financial products, companies or issuers (if applicable) and is based on sources reasonably believed to be reliable and accurate; (c) to the best of the author's knowledge, they are not in receipt of inside information and this material does not contain inside information; and (d) no other part of the Westpac Group has made any attempt to influence this material.

**Further important information regarding sustainability-related content:** This material may contain statements relating to environmental, social and governance (ESG) topics. These are subject to known and unknown risks, and there are significant uncertainties, limitations, risks and assumptions in the metrics, modelling, data, scenarios, reporting and analysis on which the statements rely. In particular, these areas are rapidly evolving and maturing, and there are variations in approaches and common standards and practice, as well as uncertainty around future related policy and legislation. Some material may include information derived from publicly available sources that have not been independently verified. No representation or warranty is made as to the accuracy, completeness or reliability of the information. There is a risk that the analysis, estimates, judgements, assumptions, views, models, scenarios or projections used may turn out to be incorrect. These risks may cause actual outcomes to differ materially from those expressed or implied. The ESG-related statements in this material do not constitute advice, nor are they guarantees or predictions of future performance, and Westpac gives no representation, warranty or assurance (including as to the quality, accuracy or completeness of the statements). You should seek your own independent advice.

#### **Additional country disclosures:**

**Australia:** Westpac holds an Australian Financial Services Licence (No. 233714). You can access Westpac's Financial Services Guide [here](#) or request a copy from your Westpac point of contact. To the extent that this information contains any general advice, it has been prepared without taking into account your objectives, financial situation or needs and before acting on it you should consider the



appropriateness of the advice.

**New Zealand:** In New Zealand, Westpac Institutional Bank refers to the brand under which products and services are provided by either Westpac (NZ division) or Westpac New Zealand Limited (company number 1763882), the New Zealand incorporated subsidiary of Westpac ("WNZL"). Any product or service made available by WNZL does not represent an offer from Westpac or any of its subsidiaries (other than WNZL). Neither Westpac nor its other subsidiaries guarantee or otherwise support the performance of WNZL in respect of any such product. WNZL is not an authorised deposit-taking institution for the purposes of Australian prudential standards. The current disclosure statements for the New Zealand branch of Westpac and WNZL can be obtained at the internet address [www.westpac.co.nz](http://www.westpac.co.nz).

**Singapore:** This material has been prepared and issued for distribution in Singapore to institutional investors, accredited investors and expert investors (as defined in the applicable Singapore laws and regulations) only. Recipients of this material in Singapore should contact Westpac Singapore Branch in respect of any matters arising from, or in connection with, this material. Westpac Singapore Branch holds a wholesale banking licence and is subject to supervision by the Monetary Authority of Singapore.

**Fiji:** Unless otherwise specified, the products and services for Westpac Fiji are available from [www.westpac.com.fj](http://www.westpac.com.fj) © Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141. This information does not take your personal circumstances into account and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the information for your financial situation. Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 is incorporated in NSW Australia and registered as a branch in Fiji. The liability of its members is limited.

**Papua New Guinea:** Unless otherwise specified, the products and services for Westpac PNG are available from [www.westpac.com.pg](http://www.westpac.com.pg) © Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141. This information does not take your personal circumstances into account and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the information for your financial situation. Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 is incorporated in NSW Australia. Westpac is represented in Papua New Guinea by Westpac Bank - PNG - Limited. The liability of its members is limited.

**U.S.:** Westpac operates in the United States of America as a federally licensed branch, regulated by the Office of the Comptroller of the Currency. Westpac is also registered with the US Commodity Futures Trading Commission ("CFTC") as a Swap Dealer, but is neither registered as, or affiliated with, a Futures Commission Merchant registered with the US CFTC. The services and products referenced above are not insured by the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation ("FDIC"). Westpac Capital Markets, LLC ('WCM'), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Westpac, is a broker-dealer registered under the U.S. Securities Exchange Act of 1934 ('the Exchange Act') and member of the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority ('FINRA'). In accordance with APRA's Prudential Standard 222 'Association with Related Entities', Westpac does not stand behind WCM other than as provided for in certain legal agreements between Westpac and WCM and obligations of WCM do not represent



liabilities of Westpac.

This communication is provided for distribution to U.S. institutional investors in reliance on the exemption from registration provided by Rule 15a-6 under the Exchange Act and is not subject to all of the independence and disclosure standards applicable to debt research reports prepared for retail investors in the United States. WCM is the U.S. distributor of this communication and accepts responsibility for the contents of this communication. Transactions by U.S. customers of any securities referenced herein should be effected through WCM. All disclaimers set out with respect to Westpac apply equally to WCM. If you would like to speak to someone regarding any security mentioned herein, please contact WCM on +1 212 389 1269. Investing in any non-U.S. securities or related financial instruments mentioned in this communication may present certain risks. The securities of non-U.S. issuers may not be registered with, or be subject to the regulations of, the SEC in the United States. Information on such non-U.S. securities or related financial instruments may be limited. Non-U.S. companies may not be subject to audit and reporting standards and regulatory requirements comparable to those in effect in the United States. The value of any investment or income from any securities or related derivative instruments denominated in a currency other than U.S. dollars is subject to exchange rate fluctuations that may have a positive or adverse effect on the value of or income from such securities or related derivative instruments.

The author of this communication is employed by Westpac and is not registered or qualified as a research analyst, representative, or associated person of WCM or any other U.S. broker-dealer under the rules of FINRA, any other U.S. self-regulatory organisation, or the laws, rules or regulations of any State. Unless otherwise specifically stated, the views expressed herein are solely those of the author and may differ from the information, views or analysis expressed by Westpac and/or its affiliates.

**UK:** The London branch of Westpac is authorised in the United Kingdom by the Prudential Regulation Authority (PRA) and is subject to regulation by the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA) and limited regulation by the PRA (Financial Services Register number: 124586). The London branch of Westpac is registered at Companies House as a branch established in the United Kingdom (Branch No. BR000106). Details about the extent of the regulation of Westpac's London branch by the PRA are available from us on request.

This communication is not being made to or distributed to, and must not be passed on to, the general public in the United Kingdom. Rather, this communication is being made only to and is directed at (a) those persons falling within the definition of Investment Professionals (set out in Article 19(5) of the Financial Services and Markets Act 2000 (Financial Promotion) Order 2005 (the "Order")); (b) those persons falling within the definition of high net worth companies, unincorporated associations etc. (set out in Article 49(2) of the Order; (c) other persons to whom it may lawfully be communicated in accordance with the Order or (d) any persons to whom it may otherwise lawfully be made (all such persons together being referred to as "relevant persons"). Any person who is not a relevant person should not act or rely on this communication or any of its contents. In the same way, the information contained in this communication is intended for "eligible counterparties" and

“professional clients” as defined by the rules of the Financial Conduct Authority and is not intended for “retail clients”. Westpac expressly prohibits you from passing on the information in this communication to any third party.

**European Economic Area (“EEA”):** This material may be distributed to you by either: (i) Westpac directly, or (ii) Westpac Europe GmbH (“WEG”) under a sub-licensing arrangement. WEG has not edited or otherwise modified the content of this material. WEG is authorised in Germany by the Federal Financial Supervision Authority (‘BaFin’) and subject to its regulation. WEG’s supervisory authorities are BaFin and the German Federal Bank (‘Deutsche Bundesbank’). WEG is registered with the commercial register (‘Handelsregister’) of the local court of Frankfurt am Main under registration number HRB 118483. In accordance with APRA’s Prudential Standard 222 ‘Association with Related Entities’, Westpac does not stand behind WEG other than as provided for in certain legal agreements (a risk transfer, sub-participation and collateral agreement) between Westpac and WEG and obligations of WEG do not represent liabilities of Westpac. Any product or service made available by WEG does not represent an offer from Westpac or any of its subsidiaries (other than WEG). All disclaimers set out with respect to Westpac apply equally to WEG.

This communication is not intended for distribution to, or use by any person or entity in any jurisdiction or country where such distribution or use would be contrary to local law or regulation.

This communication contains general commentary, research, and market colour. The communication does not constitute investment advice. The material may contain an ‘investment recommendation’ and/or ‘information recommending or suggesting an investment’, both as defined in Regulation (EU) No 596/2014 (including as applicable in the United Kingdom) (“MAR”). In accordance with the relevant provisions of MAR, reasonable care has been taken to ensure that the material has been objectively presented and that interests or conflicts of interest of the sender concerning the financial instruments to which that information relates have been disclosed.

Investment recommendations must be read alongside the specific disclosure which accompanies them and the general disclosure which can be found [here](#). Such disclosure fulfils certain additional information requirements of MAR and associated delegated legislation and by accepting this communication you acknowledge that you are aware of the existence of such additional disclosure and its contents.

To the extent this communication comprises an investment recommendation it is classified as non-independent research. It has not been prepared in accordance with legal requirements designed to promote the independence of investment research and therefore constitutes a marketing communication. Further, this communication is not subject to any prohibition on dealing ahead of the dissemination of investment research.